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Essay 2 – Relationship Building

Turning a relationship into evidence: what Chevening rewards, common failure patterns, and how to write the influence essay well.

ABOUT THE EXAMPLES.

All names, institutions and statistics below are anonymised and reinvented versions of successful essays, changed to show technique. Yours must be real.

THE LIVE QUESTION (2026).

Tell us about a professional relationship/network you have built and maintained in your workplace or in the community. In your answer, please address:

- How was the relationship formed, and what made it important?
- What did you contribute to this relationship, and what did you gain?
- How have you sustained or developed this relationship over time?
- How will these skills help you build connections within the Chevening community and beyond?

WORD LIMIT:

Minimum 100 / Maximum 300 words.

WHAT IS BEING SCORED.

Not sociability, and not the seniority of the people you know. Chevening's criteria ask for collaboration producing real, measurable outcomes: how you brought people together, and what changed as a result.

STRUCTURE.

STARL, with the L doing double duty. The learning is the transferable method; the Chevening paragraph is that method applied forwards.

ALTERNATIVE FRAME.

Connection, then trust, then contribution, then collaboration, then result, then continued relationship. Equivalent beats; use whichever you can hold in your head.

WORD PLAN AT 300 WORDS.

S 55, T 35, A 90, R 50, L and Chevening 70.

Part one: what this question actually tests

Applicants read "networking" and write about their personality. Assessors want something narrower: evidence that you can build a working alliance with somebody whose cooperation you need and cannot

compel, and that the alliance produced a result.

Three things must therefore be in the essay, and most drafts contain none of them.

A named counterpart with a title. Not a category of people and not a philosophy. One person or one body, named, positioned in the system, described specifically enough to feel real.

An exchange. What you brought and what you gained, both directions. If your mentor gave and you received, that is patronage rather than partnership.

An outcome with a number or a named artefact attached. Something the two of you produced that neither would have produced alone.

What this essay is not

Not a list of countries visited, conferences attended, famous people met, memberships held or connections collected. The question is not how large your network is. It is what you do with professional relationships.

The network test. Does your draft prove that you build relationships producing results, or only that you know people? If the second, rebuild it around one relationship and one outcome.

Part two: naming, in this essay

This is the essay where naming does the most work and where applicants are most reluctant to use it, usually out of modesty.

Name the counterpart, with their position. "Mr Joseph Adeyemi, chair of the Katiba Small Installers' Association" tells the reader where in the system he sits, which is why the relationship matters. "A stakeholder in the sector" tells them nothing.

Name the forum where you met. The National Health Financing Forum. The Standards Review Workshop. A named fellowship cohort. It converts a vague meeting into a professional setting.

Name the broker and the introduction. If the relationship produced an introduction that produced an outcome, name both ends. This is the single clearest demonstration that you have a network rather than an acquaintance.

Name the joint output. The consultation response, the co-authored chapter, the memorandum, the revised framework, by what it is called.

The rule again: name and action in the same sentence. Four to eight proper nouns in 300 words, every one attached to something you did together.

When not to name. Do not name beneficiaries, service users, patients or minors. Do not name a person you could not discuss for two minutes at interview. Recognition does not transfer; relationships do.

Part three: choosing the relationship

Pick one. The question says a relationship, singular, and depth earns the mark.

Who the counterpart can be

A colleague, a supervisor, a researcher, a policymaker, an entrepreneur, a community leader, an employer, an international collaborator, a mentor, a professional association, or an institution rather than an individual. It does not have to be somebody senior.

Four questions to test a candidate

1. What did we build together that neither of us would have built alone?
2. What did I bring? Skill, access, evidence, delivery, credibility, or the willingness to do work nobody else would.
3. How did the relationship change state over time?
4. Can I attach a number or a named artefact to what came out of it?

Strong and weak candidates

STRONG	WEAK
A counterpart in another institution you had no authority over	Your line manager
Somebody who began as an obstacle or a critic	A friend from your degree
A community body with reason to distrust your employer	A famous person you met once
A mentor who became a collaborator	A mentor who stayed only a mentor
A peer in another discipline whose method you needed	Somebody whose function is to be impressive

The best category, if you have it, is the relationship that began in disagreement. It demonstrates influence rather than affinity, and it is rare in the pile.

Part four: writing it, beat by beat

S. Situation, how it formed, around 55 words

Name the setting, name the person, and say why the relationship was necessary to you at that moment.

Frame the gap as distance, not need. Who did you have to reach, and why were they out of reach? A professional silo, an institutional boundary, a hierarchy, a community with no reason to trust your employer, a discipline whose language you did not speak. The distance is what makes the relationship an achievement rather than a coincidence of employment.

Variant one, the capability you lacked.

"Moving from a ward at St Anselm's into budget work, I had the clinical knowledge and no standing with the people who set allocations. At the National Health Financing Forum I met Mr Peter Danso of the Molo District Finance Office, who had the opposite problem: authority to reallocate, and no sense of what a ward consumes."

Variant two, persistence rather than a single meeting.

"I met Dr Ruth Nyaga as an intern at the Bureau of Statistics and told her plainly that survey design was the field I wanted. I kept turning up to the Bureau's monthly methods seminars for a year. She later taught me sampling at the Regional Statistical Training Centre, and then supervised my first survey module."

Variant three, the relationship that began as friction.

"Mr Joseph Adeyemi had spent an hour at the Standards Review Workshop explaining why our draft licensing thresholds would push half the members of the Katiba Small Installers' Association into informality. Rather than defend the draft, I asked him to walk me through it properly."

Variant four, the relationship you had to earn access to.

"The Riverine Growers' Union had been surveyed four times in three years and seen nothing come back. Their chair, Mrs Grace Owusu, told me they would not sit for a fifth. I offered to publish whatever we found in the Union's own newsletter before it went to the ministry."

Cross-boundary work counts double. If the relationship crossed a boundary of culture, language, sector, discipline or country, say so in a clause. Chevening exists to build relationships across exactly those lines.

On opening with a definition of networking. If you want a framing line, make it operational and keep it to a clause. "I build relationships around a problem rather than a job title" earns its place. "Networking, to me, is about genuine human connection" does not.

T. Task, the shared goal, around 35 words

Name the specific thing you were both trying to achieve. Narrow and technical beats broad and worthy, because a narrow aim explains why two busy people kept meeting for four years.

"We agreed on one aim: a tiered licence that let small installers operate legally without pretending they were utilities."

"We wanted a single indicator for informal-sector employment added to the National Labour Force Survey."

Compare "we shared a passion for development", which explains nothing about why either of you attended the second meeting.

A. Action: what you gave, what you gained, how you sustained it, around 90 words

State the exchange as a transaction, both directions, in that order.

"What I brought was access and analysis. I turned the Association's complaints into an evidence submission the ministry could act on, modelling compliance cost against installer revenue at each threshold. What I gained was a reality check I could never have got from the file: how quotes are priced, why paperwork gets abandoned, which rules are simply ignored."

What you brought can take many forms. Applicants often assume they had nothing to offer a senior counterpart, which is rarely true. Shared expertise. A useful introduction. Research or data nobody else held. Connecting two organisations. Solving something that was blocking them. Resources or time. Supporting their project. Doing the work nobody else would.

Show the cultivation. How did you build the bridge deliberately? A mutual contact who introduced you. A forum you kept attending. Analysis you sent unprompted. An offer to publish their findings first. Deliberate strategy is what separates relationship-building from coincidence.

Work both directions of the hierarchy. Strong applicants show they build horizontally, with peers, community members and counterparts, and vertically, with ministers, chief executives, regulators and delegates. If your example is entirely vertical, one clause about the community end is worth including.

Show maintenance as work, not goodwill. Use the escalation ladder: visible stages across stated time.

"Over four years we have sustained it through output rather than contact, co-drafting two consultation responses, running five installer workshops, and jointly presenting the tiered proposal to the National Energy Regulatory Commission."

The words doing real work are "over four years". Duration is evidence and most applicants never supply it.

What maintenance looks like on the page. You stayed in contact across institutions or countries. You collaborated again. You shared opportunities both ways. You published together. You supported them through a difficult period. You introduced them onward. "We remain in touch" answers nothing.

Network multiplication, with the broker named.

"Mr Adeyemi introduced me to Mrs Beatrice Kwarteng, who chairs the Regional Installers' Forum, which is how the proposal reached the Commission's agenda at all."

R. Result, around 50 words

What changed, with a number or a named artefact, and what the relationship is now.

"The Commission adopted the tiered licence in 2024. Registered small installers in Katiba rose from 60 to 214 the following year. He now calls me before submissions rather than after them."

That last sentence earns its place. Assessors are marking "maintained", and a relationship described entirely in the past tense does not evidence it.

Outcomes that count. A signed memorandum. A co-authored paper, submission or policy document. A joint initiative still running. A change to a rule, a form or a standard, named. A body that now convenes because you convened it. Funding secured jointly. Attach a number if you have one, and never invent one.

Optional transfer example. One sentence showing the same method in a second setting proves it is a technique rather than a lucky friendship.

"I used the same approach with the Cold Chain Operators' Group, where I now chair the joint technical panel."

L. Learning and the Chevening plan, around 70 words

One, the method, named.

"I build relationships around a specific shared problem rather than a job title."

Two, whom you will seek out in the Chevening community, and for what. Name a gap you are positioned to fill.

"I will use Chevening events to build a working group of energy regulators from countries at a similar stage of grid liberalisation, a group in which women practitioners are markedly under-represented, and seek out alumni working on informal-sector regulation for joint research."

Three, what you will contribute. The alumni community runs to tens of thousands across government, industry and civil society. Committees ask both which doors it opens and what you bring. An answer missing the second half reads as though you want the degree rather than the network.

What you can offer is broader than you think: professional expertise, regional or country knowledge few in the cohort will have, sector experience, research interests, a cultural perspective, problem-solving experience, your own relationships, and a willingness to introduce people to each other.

"Katiba has run informal-sector licensing for a decade, and I would host visiting scholars in that regime rather than only visiting theirs."

Part five: two full sample answers

Sample one, civil registration (298 words)

All names anonymised and reinvented.

Registration reform in Katiba failed twice before I arrived because it was designed in the capital. The people who could make it work were midwives, and my employer, the Institute for Public Administration, had no standing with them at all. At a maternal health review in Sisan, Mrs Esther

Bediako, president of the Katiba Midwives' Association, told me plainly that her members had been "consulted" three times and never told the outcome. [S]

We set one aim: getting the birth notification slip issued at delivery rather than at the registrar's office, which is where families were being lost. [T]

I brought the evidence and the route into government. I ran the three-province study that showed 71 per cent of unregistered children had been born with a skilled attendant present, and I took it to the Registrar General's office. Mrs Bediako brought legitimacy I did not have, convening four member consultations I could never have called. Over three years we have sustained it through joint work: co-drafting the notification protocol, training 34 midwives together, and presenting twice to the Civil Registration Technical Advisory Group. She introduced me to Dr Amina Sesay, the Registrar General, which is how the protocol reached national consideration. [A]

The protocol was issued as national guidance in 2025, and 3,142 children have been registered through it in Katiba alone. Mrs Bediako now sits on the advisory group in her own right, which she does independently of me. [R]

I learned that the sharpest critic of your programme is usually its most useful collaborator, because they have already done the analysis. Through Chevening I want to find alumni working on civil registration in comparable systems and propose a comparative study. I can offer a protocol that survived the full political process, including the parts that failed. [L]

Sample two, school inspection (297 words)

The Katiba Inspectorate published school ratings that head teachers regarded as arbitrary, and compliance with our recommendations sat at 31 per cent. At a regional heads' meeting convened largely to complain about us, Mrs Doris Ankrah, head of Sisan Girls' Secondary, took the inspection framework apart clause by clause in front of forty colleagues. She was right about most of it. I asked whether she would help me rewrite it. [S]

We set ourselves one objective: a framework head teachers could predict, measuring what a school can actually control. [T]

I brought the data and the institutional route. I ran the analysis showing which of our eighteen indicators had no relationship with pupil outcomes, and I got the revision onto the Inspectorate's agenda. She brought legitimacy I did not have, convening three consultation sessions in schools that would not have opened their doors to me. Over three years we kept it going through joint work rather than goodwill: piloting the revised framework in eleven schools, co-presenting twice to the Ministry of Education, and running the annual induction for new inspectors together. [A]

The revised framework was adopted regionally in 2025, compliance with inspection recommendations rose from 31 per cent to 68 in the first year, and four neighbouring regions have requested the induction materials. Mrs Ankrah now chairs the heads' panel that reviews the framework annually. [R]

I learned to build around a shared technical problem rather than a title. In the Chevening community I want to find alumni working on school accountability, particularly in systems moving from compliance

inspection toward improvement models, and propose a comparative study. I can contribute a framework that went through the full political process, including the two indicators we lost. [L]

What both samples do. They open on friction, in a named forum, with a named counterpart holding a stated position. They state one narrow shared aim. They give both sides of the exchange explicitly. They mark duration in years and show maintenance through joint outputs. They name the broker and the introduction. They put an exact number and a named artefact in the result, and a present-tense sentence proving the relationship is current. They close on a named gap in the alumni network and something specific offered back.

Part six: dos and don'ts

Do

- Choose one relationship and go deep
- Name the counterpart with their position, and the forum where you met
- Frame the gap as distance: who was out of reach, and why
- State one narrow, technical shared goal
- Give both sides of the exchange
- Show the deliberate move you made to build the bridge
- Show you work both horizontally and vertically
- Mark duration in years
- Show maintenance through joint output
- Name the broker if an introduction produced an outcome
- Name the joint artefact
- Prove the relationship is current with a present-tense sentence
- Name specific alumni, sectors or forums in the Chevening paragraph
- Offer something back

Don't

- Describe your networking philosophy or personality
- List contacts, conferences, memberships or countries
- Write only about what a mentor gave you
- Name a famous person as if the acquaintance were the achievement
- Name anyone you could not discuss for two minutes at interview
- Name beneficiaries, service users or minors
- Let the essay end when the job ended
- Write "I will engage with the diverse Chevening community"

- Talk only about what the network will do for you
- Invent a number to make the outcome look larger

Part seven: common mistakes, and the fix

MISTAKE	WHY IT COSTS MARKS	THE FIX
"I value honesty, trust and empathy."	Character description, not evidence.	Replace with the problem you solved together and its number.
No named network anywhere.	The most common failure on this question.	Add real people with titles, bodies and forums. Fewer than four is too few.
Names with nothing attached.	A contact list, which committees warn against.	Put the name and what you did together in one sentence.
A list of six contacts.	Depth is scored; none of the six lands.	Cut to one and spend the words on exchange and result.
Only what your mentor gave you.	Patronage, not partnership.	Add what you brought that they lacked.
The whole action paragraph is the first meeting.	Leaves "sustained" unanswered.	Add stages: what you did together in year two, and in year four.
The relationship happened to you.	Shows luck rather than skill.	Add the deliberate move you made.
Only senior contacts, or only peers.	Suggests one register.	One clause showing the other direction.
No number and no named artefact.	The missing R.	Attach a figure or name the document that changed.
Everything in the past tense.	Does not evidence maintenance.	One present-tense sentence about the relationship now.
"I will engage with the Chevening community."	Anyone could write it.	Name the sector, the gap and the joint output proposed.
Nothing offered back.	Reads as extractive.	One sentence on what you would host, share or convene.

Part eight: checklists

While drafting

- ☐ One relationship, counterpart named with their position
- ☐ The forum where it formed, and why they were out of reach
- ☐ One narrow, specific shared goal
- ☐ What I contributed stated as plainly as what I gained
- ☐ The deliberate move I made to build the bridge
- ☐ Evidence of working horizontally and vertically, if I have it
- ☐ Duration marked in years
- ☐ Maintenance shown through joint outputs
- ☐ The broker named, if an introduction produced an outcome
- ☐ One exact number or one named artefact at the result
- ☐ A present-tense sentence proving it is current

Before submitting

- ☐ All four sub-questions visibly answered
- ☐ Four to eight proper nouns, each attached to joint work
- ☐ No beneficiaries, service users or minors named
- ☐ The Chevening paragraph names a sector, a gap and a proposed output
- ☐ One line on what I contribute to the alumni community
- ☐ The essay proves I produce results through relationships
- ☐ Every figure real and every name spelled correctly
- ☐ At least one name here recurs in Essay 1 or Essay 4
- ☐ Within the word limit shown next to the box



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